Prime-field k-sum table: k = 5, and the law at 44 and 48 bits

2026-10-29

Prime-field k-sum table: k = 5, and the law at 44 and 48 bits

Track: generic decomposition (bounded by √r; cannot beat rho). Engineering in that track (AGENTS.md “Tracks of index calculus”, 2026-10-29); not algebraic progress.

Result. A table of every signed 5-sum of a smaller base lowers the prime-field index-calculus `S` below the k = 4 table of #2808. The registered success test holds: `ic-ksum5` is below `ic-ksum4` at 36 and 40 bits at every band weight (w = 0, 0.1 and 1).

- At 40 bits: `S` 8.51 against 11.56, which is 0.74×, and 0.71× at w = 1.
- At 48 bits: 0.67×.
- Fitted exponent on 36–48 bits: 0.547 [0.543, 0.554] against 0.565 [0.560, 0.571].

Distance remaining.

- At 40 bits `ic-ksum5` is **9.7× rho** (`rho-neg`) and **7.6× BSGS** (`bsgs-neg`), at w = 0.
- At 48 bits it is 11.0× rho and 10.6× BSGS.
- The method is generic. Its limit is BSGS, and it is still above BSGS at every size.

Public synthetic curves; no security claim. This study is stacked on `../prime_ksum_table_20261028/` (isogeny-labs/crypto#2808). It was registered in `PROTOCOL.md` before any timed run (hash in `REGISTRATION.sha256`).

Labels. `[measured]`: native `ecbench` records and receipts in this directory. `[derived]`: from the registered cost law. `[predicted]`: the registered table.

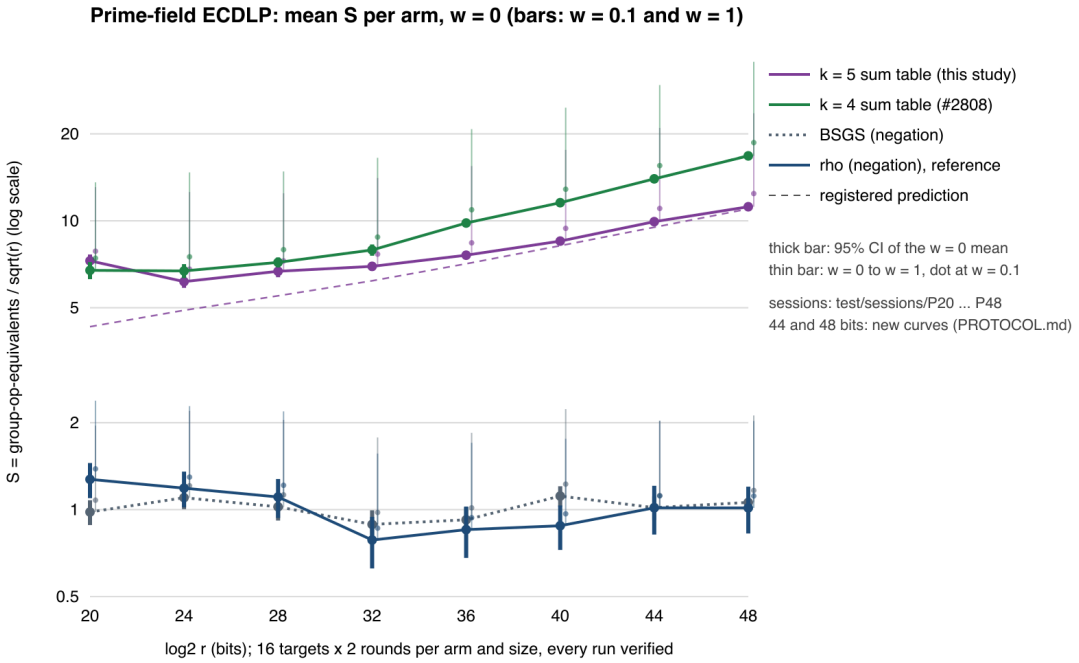


Figure 1: Mean S per arm and size at w = 0, with 95 % intervals (thick) and the w = 0 → 1 band (thin). Dashed: the registered predictions. Source: s_vs_bits.svg.

1. What changed

1. **`k = 5`.** `KSumTable` takes `k = 3, 4, 5`.
   - Its entries now pack the summand indices into one `u64`, 12 bits each, instead of `[u32; 4]`.
   - The insert order and the keep-first rule are unchanged, so group-operation counts are identical (§2).
   - Generic law: `2^{k−1}C(A,k) + c_k·A·p/(2^k C(A,k))`, with optimum exponent `k/(2k−1)`: 5/9 for `k = 5`, against 4/7.
2. **Two larger sizes.** The `prime_fast::find_a3_curve` rungs at 44 and 48 bits (curves in `PROTOCOL.md`):
   - `icv1-fp44-tm6431881-43acc95d`
   - `icv1-fp48-tm15186475-c683ebfc`

2. Integrity `[measured]`

- **Every answer verified.** 8 sessions × 240 records = 1,920 runs, every one verified.
- **`ecbench verify --replay-all` on every test session.** All 8 reproduce every replay, with 0 problems (`test/audits/`).
- **Replication, the protocol's stop condition: passed.** At 20–40 bits, `ic-ksum4` reproduces #2808's per-run counts on the same targets for all 288 of 288 runs. Cost, counters, seeds, method hash and answer are all identical (`replicate.mjs`, `analysis/replication.txt`).

- **#2808 unchanged by this code.** The PR's binary replays all six of #2808's test sessions identically: 1,344 replays, 0 problems (`analysis/replay-2808/`).
- **Binaries** (hashes in `BINARY.sha256`).
  - The train panel ran `ecbench-k5`, an earlier build of this PR's code. `ecbench-v2` replays every train record identically (`train/audits-v2/`), so the selection in `params.json` does not depend on which build measured it.
  - The test panel and every audit ran `ecbench-v2`, built from 26249b4 plus this PR's code diff. The PR merges that diff onto a later main; the receipts are of the binary named here.
- **A/A control.** `rho-neg` and `rho-neg-aa` agree exactly. They share seeds and the walk is deterministic, so this checks determinism only.

3. Results

3.1 Mean `S` per size `[measured]`

The values are w = 0 / 0.1 / 1. There are 16 targets × 2 rounds per arm and size, at seed `20261015200`. Full table: `analysis/band-prime.md`.

bits	`ic-ksum5` (A)	`ic-ksum4` (A)	k5 / k4	k5 / rho	k5 / BSGS
20	7.27 / 7.85 / 13.08 (9)	6.74 / 7.42 / 13.59 (10)	1.08 / 1.06 / 0.96	5.7 / 5.7 / 5.5	7.4 / 7.3 / 6.7
24	6.16 / 6.80 / 12.57 (11)	6.71 / 7.51 / 14.71 (14)	0.92 / 0.91 / 0.85	5.2 / 5.3 / 5.5	5.6 / 5.6 / 5.7
28	6.69 / 7.26 / 12.45 (15)	7.18 / 7.95 / 14.82 (21)	0.93 / 0.91 / 0.84	6.1 / 6.0 / 5.7	6.5 / 6.5 / 6.1
32	6.96 / 7.67 / 14.07 (19)	7.93 / 8.79 / 16.53 (30)	0.88 / 0.87 / 0.85	8.9 / 8.9 / 9.0	7.8 / 7.8 / 7.9
36	7.60 / 8.39 / 15.47 (25)	9.83 / 10.92 / 20.77 (44)	0.77 / 0.77 / 0.75	8.9 / 9.0 / 9.1	8.3 / 8.3 / 8.4
40	8.51 / 9.42 / 17.61 (33)	11.56 / 12.86 / 24.65 (64)	0.74 / 0.73 / 0.71	9.7 / 9.7 / 10.0	7.6 / 7.7 / 7.9
44	9.93 / 11.04 / 20.97 (44)	13.98 / 15.53 / 29.52 (95)	0.71 / 0.71 / 0.71	9.8 / 9.9 / 10.3	9.8 / 9.9 / 10.3
48	11.19 / 12.43 / 23.57 (59)	16.79 / 18.66 / 35.53 (140)	0.67 / 0.67 / 0.66	11.0 / 11.1 / 11.6	10.6 / 10.7 / 11.1

§5a verdicts (`ecbench band --ranks`):

- `ic-ksum5` < `ic-ksum4` across the band at every size from 24 to 48 bits.
- At 20 bits the pair is unresolved: k = 5 is dearer at w = 0 and cheaper at w = 1.
- `rho-neg` < `ic-ksum5` and `bsgs-neg` < `ic-ksum5` at every size.

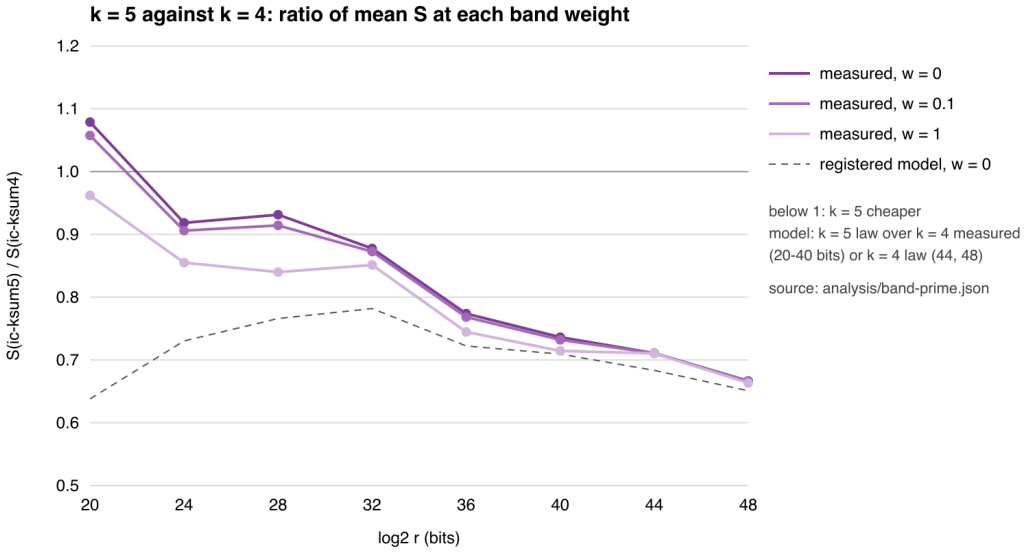


Figure 2: S(ic-ksum5) / S(ic-ksum4) at each band weight, against the registered model. Source: ratio.svg.

3.2 The law at 44 and 48 bits `[measured]` against `[predicted]`

bits	arm	A (train pick, predicted)	S measured	S predicted
44	`ic-ksum4`	95 (95)	13.98	13.9
44	`ic-ksum5`	44 (44)	9.93	9.5
48	`ic-ksum4`	140 (140)	16.79	16.9
48	`ic-ksum5`	59 (59)	11.19	11.0

The train panel picked the model optimum `A` at every size for k = 5, and at 44 and 48 bits for k = 4. Every pick was interior to its grid.

- **Below 32 bits the model is optimistic for k = 5.** It predicts 4.3 at 20 bits against 7.27 measured. At small `A` the table and the walk are not in their asymptotic regime, and the fixed costs count.
- **From 40 bits on, the measured `S` is within 5 % of prediction** for k = 5 (3.8 %, 4.5 %, 1.7 %). At 36 bits it is 7 % above. At 44 and 48 bits k = 4 is within 1 %.

Relations per base abscissa. c_5 = 1.10 at 20 bits, falling to 1.01 at 48 bits. c_4 = 0.98–1.06, as in #2808.

Table build. It takes 44–57 % of `ic-ksum5`'s operations, against 34–47 % for `ic-ksum4`.

Memory. Peak RSS at 48 bits is 6.7 GiB (k = 5) against 8.8 GiB (k = 4).

3.3 Exponents `[measured]`

These come from `ecbench bound fit --weight` per tier, with cluster-bootstrap 95 % intervals (`analysis/bounds/`). The toy tier is 20–32 bits and the medium tier 36–48 bits.

arm	toy α, w = 0 / 1	medium α, w = 0 / 1	law
`ic-ksum5`	0.499 [0.477, 0.528] / 0.509	0.547 [0.543, 0.554] / 0.552	5/9 = 0.556
`ic-ksum4`	0.521 [0.506, 0.538] / 0.523	0.565 [0.560, 0.571] / 0.565	4/7 = 0.571
`bsgs-neg`	0.484 [0.443, 0.520]	0.514 [0.481, 0.538]	1/2
`rho-neg`	0.435 [0.381, 0.492]	0.530 [0.487, 0.576]	1/2

`ic-ksum4`'s toy exponent reproduces #2808's 0.521 [0.506, 0.538] exactly. In the medium tier the two k-sum intervals are disjoint, and each lies just below its law.

4. Registered success and falsification

- **Success (engineering): holds.** At 36 and 40 bits, `ic-ksum5`'s mean `S` is below `ic-ksum4`'s at every `w` in the band (§3.1, `band` verdicts).
- **Falsifier: did not fire.** It required `ic-ksum5` to be not below `ic-ksum4` at 40 bits at some `w`. No run failed verification.
- **Law check (reported, not gating).** At 44 and 48 bits both arms are within 5 % of prediction, and `ic-ksum5 < ic-ksum4` holds across the band.

Under the owner's success criterion, this is a verified, measured improvement of the **generic-decomposition track's** baseline on these curves, labelled "generic decomposition (bounded by √r; cannot beat rho)". It does not ratchet the algebraic track, whose prime-field baseline is empty until the reference arm runs (`research/prime_ic_program_20261029/`). It runs on the frontier campaign's curves, not the leaderboard's Table B curves or the 20-bit holdout, so it is not ranked against the Table B incumbent; a same-session comparison is the next check. The distance remaining to rho is 9.7× at 40 bits (it was 13.1× with `ic-ksum4` in this panel, as in #2808), and 11.0× at 48 bits. The gain is a constant factor, because the exponent only moves from 4/7 to 5/9. Larger `k` converges to BSGS and never below it, so this family cannot reach rho.

5. Limitations and next checks

- One curve per size, all `a = −3` prime-order curves of the frontier ladder.
- The cost is counted GAE; lookups are priced only through the §5a band.
- One host. The validation gate needs an independent-host replay and a `VALIDATION.json` before a `benchmarks/` results row.
- `k = 6` (exponent 6/11, about $2^5 \cdot C(A,6)$ entries) was neither modelled nor run. It would also need a wider entry: six 12-bit indices exceed 64 bits.

6. Files

- `PROTOCOL.md`, `REGISTRATION.sha256`, `BINARY.sha256`, `params.json`, `make_specs.sh` (`bash make_specs.sh train|test`), and `base-specs/`.
- `train/` and `test/`: specs, native sessions and audits. `analyse.sh` runs the replication, the audits, `band` and the fits, in that order.
- `plot.mjs` writes the two figures from `analysis/band-prime.json` and the records.
- `report.pdf`: this README rendered.